Dig for Victory & Food Rationing

Key Enquiry Question: Why did cabbages and carrots become weapons of war on the British Home Front?

LESSON 05
KEY STAGE 2



Source A: *A famous 1940 "Dig for Victory" poster showing a young boy with a spade and hoe marching to turn garden soil into food.*

HISTORICAL READING • WHAT THIS TELLS US

Before the war, Britain imported **55 million tonnes of food** each year by merchant ship. When German U-boat submarines began sinking cargo vessels in the Atlantic, food supplies dropped dangerously low.

The government introduced rationing: every person received a Ration Book with coupons for meat, butter, sugar, and eggs. Meanwhile, the "Dig for Victory" campaign urged families to turn flowerbeds, parks, and school lawns into vegetable allotments.

Task 1: Artifact Detective • The Ministry of Food Ration Book

PRIMARY EVIDENCE



Source B: *Authentic Ministry of Food Child's Ration Book with coupons for bacon, sugar, meat, butter, and margarine. (Wellcome Collection L0072436)*

1. Look closely at Source B. Why did every citizen, rich or poor, have to register with a local grocer and surrender official paper coupons to buy basic weekly food?

2. Look at Source A. Why did the government target children and families with positive gardening posters rather than frightening them with messages of starvation?

Task 2: Active Chronological Challenge • The Battle for the Nation's Larder

CHRONOLOGICAL UNDERSTANDING

STAGE 1 • JAN 1940
Rationing Begins
Bacon, butter, and sugar rationed first. Weekly butter allowance is just 50g (two small pats) per person.
How would a family with three children change their daily breakfast routine?

STAGE 2 • OCT 1940
Dig for Victory Campaign
Lawns, flowerbeds, and golf courses ploughed. Over 1.4 million allotments produce fresh root vegetables.
Why did growing food at home directly save the lives of merchant navy sailors?

STAGE 3 • 1941
Lord Woolton & Waste Laws
Wasting food made a crime. Families collect kitchen scraps for pig clubs; mothers bake 'Woolton Pie'.
Why was throwing away stale bread or potato peelings punished with heavy fines?

Task 3: Visual Investigation • Design a Wartime Ration Dinner Plate & Recipe Ledger

TACTILE INVESTIGATION

Draw a wartime dinner plate using rationed ingredients and homegrown allotment vegetables (e.g. Woolton Pie, carrots, and potatoes).

1. The Famous 'Woolton Pie'
How did combining turnips, carrots, and potatoes with oatmeal crust create a nutritious family meal?

2. National Dried Milk & Rosehip Syrup
Why did the government provide special vitamin syrups to children and expectant mothers?

3. School Vegetable Patches
How did schoolchildren helping to dig allotments after class support the national war effort?

4. The Street Pig Club & Scrap Bins
Why did neighbours save vegetable peelings in street bins to feed community-reared pigs?

Task 4: "Thinking Heads" • Contrasting Historical Perspectives

CONTRASTING PERSPECTIVES

1 Ministry of Food Inspector

Why is it your vital national duty to prevent black-market food hoarding and ensure fair shares for every family?

2 British Mother Planning Meals

How do you use resourcefulness and imagination to stretch a tiny weekly ration of butter and meat to feed hungry children?

Task 5: Mission Challenge • Fair Shares for All

HISTORIAN CHALLENGE

Big Question: Why was the British wartime rationing system considered one of the fairest, healthiest, and most successful government social policies in modern British history?

HISTORICAL REPRODUCTION

Artefact Workshop: Ministry of Food 1940 Ration Book & Victory Pie Recipe

Craft Instructions: 1. Fill in your official wartime identity & registered grocer on the 1940 Ration Book cover. 2. Cut along the outer dashed lines and fold in half along the vertical spine. 3. Cut out your weekly rationing coupons to spend at the grocer. 4. Complete the authentic Lord Woolton Victory Pie recipe analysis on the right.

✂ CUT & FOLD IN HALF

MINISTRY OF FOOD

RATION BOOK (GENERAL) 1940–1941

FORM R.B. 1
No. RB-842915

HOLDER'S SURNAME & INITIALS: _____

NATIONAL REG. NUMBER: _____

REGISTERED HOME ADDRESS: _____

REGISTERED BUTCHER: _____

REGISTERED GROCER: _____

OFFICIAL WARNING: This book is the property of H.M. Government. You must register it with your chosen shopkeeper before purchasing food. If lost, report immediately to your Local Food Executive Officer. Heavy fines or imprisonment apply for illegal trading or coupon forgery.

✂ 8 CUT-OUT WEEKLY STAMPS

WEEKLY FOOD COUPON SHEET • WEEK 24 Detach only in presence of shopkeeper

MEAT	BACON	BUTTER	SUGAR
1s 2d	4 oz	2 oz	8 oz
Value Per Wk	1 Adult Ration	Margarine/Fat	Half Pound

TEA	CHEESE	EGGS	POINTS
2 oz	2 oz	1 FRESH	4 PTS
Leaf Ration	Hard Cheese	+ 1 Pkt Dried	Tinned / Dried

**Historian Note: A 2 oz butter ration is approximately the size of a single matchbox per person for an entire 7 days!*

MINISTRY OF FOOD • WAR COOKERY LEAFLET NO. 1

LORD WOOLTON VICTORY PIE

"Healthy, Filling, Savoury — And Not a Scrap of Imported Meat!"

OFFICIAL INGREDIENTS (SERVES 4):

- **Filling:** 1 lb diced potatoes, 1 lb carrots, 1 lb cauliflower or swede, 3 spring onions, 1 tsp Marmite (yeast extract), 1 tbsp oatmeal.
- **Potato Pastry Crust:** 8 oz cooked mashed potato, 4 oz flour, 2 oz cooking fat (saving butter!).

Method: Cook diced root vegetables with yeast extract and oatmeal until tender. Transfer to a pie dish. Roll out pastry crust made from mashed potato and flour, place over vegetables, brush with milk, and bake in a hot oven for 30 minutes until golden brown.

Pupil Historian Analysis:

1. Why did the government urge mothers to make pastry crust out of mashed potato instead of wheat flour?

2. How did growing potatoes and carrots at home protect British sailors in the Atlantic Ocean?

OFFICIAL MINISTRY OF FOOD SLOGAN: "DIG FOR VICTORY!"